

Two types of exclusive doubling in Vietnamese

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Abstract:

This study focuses on the syntax-semantic mismatches arising from doubling of exclusive focus particles ‘only’ in Vietnamese: (i) adverbial *chỉ* with adfocal *mỗi* and with (ii) sentence-final particle (SFP) *thôi*. Despite multiple occurrences, only one particle is interpreted as the exclusive operator. Following the operator-particle approach, I propose that only adverbial *chỉ* is the operator, which establishes different syntactic dependencies with *mỗi* and *thôi* that are truth-conditionally void: (i) covert movement triggered by focus [FOC] features in adverbial-adfocal doubling, and (ii) syntactic Agree with exclusive [EXCL] features in adverbial-SFP doubling. The non-uniformity is supported by their distinct locality profiles and (non-)sensitivity to intervention by quantificational elements. Furthermore, I argue that focus and quantificational elements constitute different featural classes for minimality-based intervention.

Keywords: exclusive doubling, focus, covert movement, Agree, intervention

1. Introduction

This study is concerned with exclusive focus particles in Vietnamese and their doubling. Unlike English *only* which has the same form for adverbial and adfocal/adnominal uses (cf. Horn 1969; Jackendoff 1972; Rooth 1985; also called the sentential-constituent distinction in Erlewine 2017a), Vietnamese exclusive particles have different forms, such as adverbial *chỉ* ‘only’ in (1), adfocal *mỗi* ‘only’ in (2), and a sentence-final particle (SFP) *thôi* ‘only’ in (3).¹

(1) Adverbial particle *chỉ*

Vợ ông chỉ biết [khóc]_F.

wife he only know cry

‘His wife could only weep.’

(Thompson 1965:339, adapted)

(2) Adfocal particle *mỗi*

Mỗi [Nam]_F ăn thịt bò.

PRT.only Nam eat beef

‘Only *Nam* eats beef.’

(Hole 2013:ex.15c, adapted)

(3) Sentence-final particle *thôi*

[Context: Do you want to buy a one-way ticket or a round-trip ticket?]

[Một lượt]_F thôi

one turn SFP.only

‘Just *one-way*.’

(Thompson 1965:286)

Another difference from English is that these particles in Vietnamese can often be doubled with the same focus association, where only one exclusive operator is interpreted

¹ Abbreviation of glossing in addition to the Leipzig glossing rules: CL=classifier; INTERJ=interjection; PRT=particle (for adfocal *mỗi*); SFP=sentence-final particle.

semantically (as opposed to a multiple/stacked ‘only’ reading, cf. Horn 1969). This is exemplified in (4) for *chỉ* and *mỗi*, and in (5) for *chỉ* and *thôi*. I refer to the former case as AdFoc Doubling and the latter as SFP Doubling. They differ in the relative position of the particles: adverbial *chỉ* is higher than *mỗi* (attaching to DP), but lower than *thôi* (on the sentential level).

(4) Adverbial-adjfocal exclusive doubling in Vietnamese (AdFoc Doubling)

Nam chỉ ăn mỗi [thịt bò]_F.

Nam only eat PRT.only beef

‘Nam eats only *beef*.’ (Hole 2017:394)

(5) Adverbial-SFP exclusive doubling in Vietnamese (SFP Doubling)

Tôi chỉ có [bốn đồng]_F thôi.

1SG only have four dong SFP.only

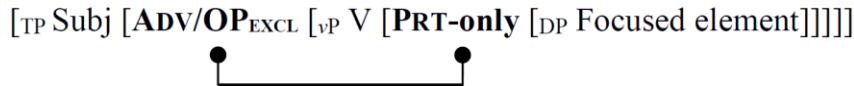
‘I have only *four piasters*.’ (Thompson 1965:339)

While it is also common in other languages to have one type of exclusive doubling or the other (e.g., Akan, Cantonese, Dutch, German, Mandarin, Thai, Yoruba; see Hole 2015; Yip 2024, 2026 and references therein), Vietnamese is special in allowing *both* types (Hole 2008, 2013, 2017; Erlewine 2017a; Quek and Hirsch 2017; Park 2020; Sun 2020, 2021, Do 2025), which serves as an excellent testing ground for different theories of exclusive doubling.

Exclusive doubling bears significant theoretical relevance to both syntax and semantics, since there is a form-meaning mismatch: two particles are interpreted as one, but not two, exclusive operator (comparable to negative concord, e.g., Labov 1972). There is hence a compositionality problem. The prevailing solution is the operator-particle approach (Bayer 1996; Y. Lee 2005; Quek and Hirsch 2017; Bassi, Hirsch, and Trinh 2022; Sun 2021; Branen

and Erlewine 2023; Aremu 2026; *i.a.*), which posits that adfocal particles are concord markers that establish a syntactic dependency with an exclusive operator (which may be pronounced as the adverbial particle, or unpronounced), as in (6).

(6) The operator-particle approach



There are, however, some unresolved issues. First, the syntactic nature of the dependency is subject to debate, which is argued to be Agree (e.g., Quek and Hirsch 2017; Hole 2017), covert movement (e.g., Bayer 1996; Y. Lee 2005), and/or overt movement (e.g., Hole 2017; Sun 2021). Second, the literature has largely focused on AdFoc Doubling, and SFP Doubling remains unaccounted for (except Yip 2024, 2025).

The paper argues that the two types of exclusive doubling in Vietnamese are formed by different syntactic dependencies. I propose that AdFoc Doubling involves covert movement triggered by focus [FOC] features, and SFP Doubling involves syntactic Agree with exclusive [EXCL] features. I offer arguments from their distinct locality profiles concerning long-distance and island configurations and from their (non-)sensitivity to intervention by quantificational elements. Moreover, I suggest that focus and quantificational elements, often conflated in the literature of syntactic minimality (e.g., Rizzi 2001, 2004), should be separated as different classes.

The data are collected through two means: (i) in interview sessions with four primary consultants in 2023-2025; and (ii) during two field trips in Vietnam (Hanoi, Saigon, and Dalat; covering both Northern Vietnamese and Southern Vietnamese) using storyboard elicitation, translation, and naturalness judgment task (on a Likert scale from 1 to 7). The storyboards can be found in the supplementary materials. The dataset is based on 33 participants and was collected in July-August 2024 and December 2024-January 2025. Most

examples were elicited from and/or confirmed by at least 19 speakers (some by more, up to 24), with a few exceptions that will be specified whenever appropriate.

While the empirical scope of this paper is on adverbial *chỉ*, adfocal *mỗi*, and SFP *thôi*, Vietnamese has other focus particles that may be translated as ‘only’ or ‘just’. Some examples include adverbial *vốn vện/ vển vện* ‘just, merely’, adverbial *chỉ riêng* ‘solely, alone’, adjectival *duy nhất/ độc nhất* ‘only, sole’, and even *những*, primarily used as a plural marker but can also mean ‘only’ in the old times (e.g., Emeneau 1951:34,88), with residue uses like *không những...mà còn* ‘not only...but also’ in Modern Vietnamese. There is also a leftward associating particle *mới* ‘only then, just; (lit.) new’, argued to be a scalar particle by Hole (2017) and a scale-sensitive exclusive particle by Tran and Zimmermann (2021).² When the focus undergoes the movement, *mới* is obligatory. As illustrated in (7), *mới* may also be doubled with other exclusive particles, forming a “quadrupling” case.

(7) *Nam chỉ mỗi [thịt bò]_F mới ăn _ thôi.*

Nam only PRT.only beef just eat SFP.only

‘Only *beef* does Nam eat.’

(Hole 2017:390)

The current paper sets these other focus particles aside. That said, the tests developed here may readily be extended to them in future research.

The rest of this paper is organized as follows. §2 introduces basic syntactic and focus association properties of the three exclusive particles in Vietnamese. §3 examines asymmetries in locality and intervention effects of AdFoc Doubling and SFP Doubling. §4 offers a syntactic account to both types of doubling, arguing for different dependencies

² See also Nguyen (2013) for a pronominal view to *mới* as well as *cũng* ‘also’ in the so-called “particle collisions”.

involved. §5 concludes the paper and remarks on a less discussed semantic facet of exclusive doubling with scalarity.

2. The syntax of three exclusive particles in Vietnamese

This section examines the syntax of adverbial *chỉ* (§2.1), adfocal *mỗi* (§2.2), and sentence-final *thôi* (§2.3), with evidence from (i) focus association, (ii) embedding, and (iii) relative order to other functional heads.

2.1. Adverbial particle *chỉ*

The adverbial exclusive focus particle *chỉ* is well-studied (Hole 2008, 2013, 2017; Nguyen 2013; Erlewine 2017a; Quek and Hirsch 2017; Park 2020; Sun 2020, 2021; Do 2025). While most scholars agree that *chỉ* is an adverb with flexible attachment sites (e.g., Hole 2017; Erlewine 2017a), Sun (2021) assumes it to project a Foc(us) head above vP. I will provide new observation based on my own fieldwork data to determine its syntactic status.

Consider focus association first. *Chỉ* may associate at a distance with different foci in the VP domain, including objects, verbs, and the whole VP. When appearing in the pre-subject position, it only associates with the subject, but not VP materials (cf. Erlewine 2017a). The patterns are exemplified by (8), elicited from a storyboard “Christmas party”. An example of verbal focus is cited from Erlewine (2017a) in (9).

(8) Association of *chỉ* with focus

a. Christmas-party-7

Nam **chỉ** tặng [túi xách]_F cho cô ấy. (DO focus)

Nam only give handbag to her

‘Nam only gave a handbag (but not flowers) to her.’

b. Christmas-party-6

Nam **chỉ** *tặng hoa cho [cô ấy]_F.* (IO focus)

Nam only give flower to her

‘Nam only gave a handbag to *her* (but not other girls).’

c. Christmas-party-10

Nam nghĩ mình nên **chỉ** *[tặng hoa cho Linh]_F.* (VP focus)

Nam think self should only give flowers to Linh

‘Nam thinks that he should have only *given flowers to Linh* (and should not give handbags to other girls).’

d. Christmas-party-5

Chỉ *[Linh]_F nói đồng ý.* (Subject focus)

only Linh say agree

‘Only *Linh* (but not other people) said yes.’

(9) *Nam* **chỉ** *[MUA]_F cuốn sách.* (V focus)

Nam only buy CL book

‘Nam only *bought* the book.’

i.e., Nam didn’t do anything else with the book (e.g., read it). (Erlewine 2017a:326)

Chỉ can even associate with moved objects above subjects as in (10), though it is marked for some speakers. Thus, *chỉ* can attach higher than TP in the CP layer.

(10) %**Chỉ** *(có) [cuốn sách này]_F Nam đọc thôi.* (Moved object focus)

only have CL book this Nam read SFP.only

‘Only *this book*, Nam read.’ (mean=5.08/7, n=12)

Chỉ can also associate with *wh*-nominals, as illustrated in (11) (see Li and Law 2016; Erlewine 2025 for association with *wh*-words of *zhi* ‘only’ in Mandarin).

(11) Association of *chỉ* with *wh*-nominals

Nó chỉ ăn [cái gì]_F?

3SG only eat what

Lit.: ‘S/he only ate *what?*’ i.e., ‘What is *x* such that s/he only ate *x?*’

Second, consider embedding. *Chỉ* generally cannot occur within a VP in a postverbal position, as in (12).³

(12) The ban on postverbal *chỉ*

a. **Hôm qua Nam [VP đọc chỉ [sách]_F].*

yesterday Nam read only book

b. *Hôm qua Nam chỉ [VP đọc [sách]_F].*

yesterday Nam only read book

‘Nam only read *books* yesterday.’

While postverbal *chỉ* is reported by Erlewine (2017a) such as in (13)a (pipe “|” indicates a pause), he argues that such cases involve a biclausal structure where *chỉ* is still in a preverbal position, as evidenced by the pause and the possibility of *có* ‘have’ (which cannot be added after a preverbal *chỉ*). He provides the biclausal source in (13)b. I follow him and maintain

³ There is speaker variation on (12)a. While most speakers judged it as 1/7, a few speakers found it completely natural and judged it as 7/7 (not even marginal). It is possible that those speakers allow a biclausal parsing more easily, as discussed below.

that *chỉ* must occur preverbally.

(13)a. *Tôi đọc *(l) chỉ (có) cuốn sách [này]_F.*

I read only have CL book this

‘I only read *this book*.’

b. *[Tôi đọc nó]. [Chỉ (có) cuốn sách [này]_F].*

I read it only have CL book this

‘I read it. Only *this book*.’

(Erlewine 2017a:332-333)

Chỉ can be regularly embedded under CP such as the adverbial clause in (14), as well as under (nonfinite) TP under *bắt* ‘force’ in (15).

(14) ***Chỉ* can be embedded in CP**

*[_{CP} Nếu con **chỉ** ăn [thịt bò]_F], thì mẹ sẽ đánh con.*

if 2SG only eat beef then mom will hit 2SG

‘If you only eat *beef*, mum will beat you up.’

(15) ***Chỉ* can be embedded in TP**

*Thầy giáo bắt Nam [_{TP} **chỉ** học [tiếng Pháp]_F]. (Không được học tiếng Anh.)*

teacher force Nam only study French not may study English

‘The teacher forces Nam to only study *French*.’ (He cannot study English)

Chỉ may also be embedded under nonfinite clauses taken by *bắt đầu* ‘begin’ as in (16)a, which is natural for around half of the speakers (6-7/7) and slightly degraded for the others (4-5/7). Following Wurmbrand and Lohninger (2023), I assume that verbs like ‘begin’ take an “event” complement and project a vP (see also Huang 2022, Liu & Yip 2026). (16)b

shows another case of *chỉ* under the vP-embedding verb *thử* ‘try’.

(16) ***Chỉ* can be embedded in vP**

a. (?) *Tôi bắt đầu* [_{vP} ***chỉ*** *đọc sách* [*tiếng Anh*]_F].

1SG begin only read book English

‘I begin to only read *English* books (but not books in other languages).’

(mean=6/7, n=22)

b. *Nam thử* [_{vP} ***chỉ*** *đọc sách* [*tiếng Anh*]_F].

Nam try only read book English

‘Nam tries to only read *English* books (but not books in other languages).’

Support for the vP size comes from the ban on embedded tense and aspect markers, including past tense *đã*, future *sẽ* and durative/progressive *đang*, as in (17).

(17) **Tôi bắt đầu* [_{vP} {***đã***/ ***sẽ***/ ***đang***} *đọc sách tiếng Anh*].

1SG begin PST FUT DUR read book English

Int.: ‘I begin to {have read/ be about to read/ be reading} English books.’

When we consider the ordering of *chỉ* with other elements, interestingly, *chỉ* can only follow tense markers like *đã* and/or *sẽ* but not before them in (18), as reported by Hole (2013) and Do (2025), also confirmed by my consultants. In contrast, *chỉ* may precede the aspect marker *đang* in (19).

(18) **Chỉ cannot precede tense markers**

a. *Nam {*chỉ} đã/ sẽ {chỉ} ăn [pho mát]_F.*

Nam only PST FUT only eat cheese

Int.: ‘Nam only ate cheese.’/ ‘Nam will only eat cheese.’

(Hole 2013:ex.7b)

b. **Tôi chỉ {đã/ sẽ} mua [sách]_F.*

1SG only PST FUT buy book

Int.: ‘I only bought *books*.’/ ‘I will only buy *books*.’

(Do 2025:ex.33a)

(19) **Chỉ can precede aspect markers**

Nam chỉ đang đọc [cuốn sách]_F thôi.

Nam only DUR read CL book SFP.only

‘Nam is only reading *the book*.’

These tense markers are usually argued to occupy a T head or an Asp head moved to T (for *đã*), such as by Duffield (2017) and Trang Phan (2023). They cannot follow the negation *không* as in (20), as opposed to *chỉ* as in (21) (from two storyboards).⁴

(20) **Đã and sẽ cannot follow a negation**

a. *Tôi {sẽ} không {*sẽ} làm việc đó.*

1SG FUT not FUT do job that

‘I will not do that.’

b. *Tôi {đã} không {*đã} làm việc đó.*

1SG PST not PST do job that

‘I didn’t do that.’

(Duffield 2017:356)

⁴ *Chỉ* may also precede a negation, see §3.2.

(21) *Chỉ* can follow a negation

a. Christmas-party-8

Nam không *chỉ* tặng túi xách cho [cô ấy]_F.

Nam not only give handbag to her

‘Nam did not only give a handbag to *her*.’

b. Karaoke-12

Bạn không *chỉ* hát [ba bài]_F!

you not only sing three CL

‘You didn’t only sing *three* (songs)!’

The above patterns suggest that *chỉ* cannot be higher than T, thus it cannot precede *đã/ sẽ*. This at first glance seems to support Sun’s (2021) analysis that *chỉ* projects a Foc head above ν P, lower than TP. However, recall that *chỉ* can occur above subjects (cf. (8)d, (10)). Subjects in Vietnamese occupy SpecTP, as evidenced by the ban on pre-subject *đã* and *sẽ* in (22).

(22) * {*Đã/ Sẽ*} Nam đọc cuốn sách này.

PST FUT Nam read CL book this

Int.: ‘Nam read this book.’/ ‘Nam will read this book.’

Importantly, pre-subject *chỉ* can co-occur with *đã* and *sẽ*, as in (23):

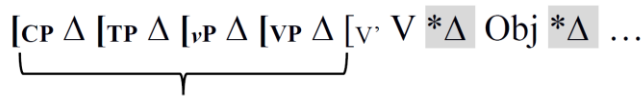
(23) *Chỉ* [Nam]_F {*đã* / *sẽ*} đọc [cuốn sách này]_F.

only Nam PST FUT read CL book this

‘Only *Nam* read this book.’/ ‘Only *Nam* will read this book.’

Hence, *chi* can attach to positions above TP. Since *chi* may associate with moved object focus (above subjects) but can also be embedded inside vP, I conclude that *chi* is an adverb with flexible attachment sites ranging from as low as to VP to as high as to CP, rather than a Foc head above vP (*pace* Sun 2021).⁵ Since it is an adverb, it cannot occur in a postverbal position. Its syntax is given in (24) (Δ indicates attachment sites).

(24) **The syntax of the adverbial particle *chi***



Flexible adjunction sites of *chi*

I speculate that the ban on **chi dǎ/sě* strings is due to a constraint of attaching *chi* as soon as focus association is possible, following Erlewine (2017a:342)’s Adjoin As Soon As Possible. It states that adjuncts should be adjoined as soon as they are interpretable. Erlewine utilizes it to explain why pre-subject *chi* can only associate with subjects instead of VP materials (as in (8)d), because had the focus association been with VP, *chi* should have attached to a position right above VP, whereas attaching to TP is too high/“late” for that.

Returning to the case with tense markers in (18), the focus is within the VP domain.

Assuming that tense contributes presuppositions (Abusch 1997; cf. Partee 1973), attaching *chi* above T does not yield a meaning difference. Thus, *chi* must attach to the VP, rather than

⁵ Sun (2020:ex.26) suggests that *chi*’s projection (labeled as OpP) can also be higher than TP. While this can handle both pre-subject *chi* and the ban on post-subject *chi* with *dǎ/sě*, it raises questions on how many FocP/OpP are needed on the clausal spine, given that *chi* has many possible positions. It also fails to explain the ban on VP association of pre-subject *chi* (cf. Erlewine 2017a). See §4.1 for another issue of counter-cyclic operations in her analysis.

in the TP layer below subjects.⁶ This also means that *chỉ* should be an adjunct rather than a functional head, the latter of which is instead constrained by selection restrictions on a functional sequence.

2.2. Adfocal particle *mỗi*

The focus particle use of *mỗi* is not reported in early reference grammars by Emeneau (1951) and Thomspon (1965). *Mỗi* is only described as a universal quantifier ‘each’, similar to *mọi* ‘every’ (see Cao 2025 for a detailed study), which should be distinguished from the adfocal use translated as ‘only’.⁷ I assume that adfocal *mỗi* and universal *mỗi* are different morphemes. To the best of my knowledge, Hole (2008, *et seq.*) is the first to document and systematically study adfocal *mỗi*, followed by Erlewine (2017a), Quek & Hirsch (2017), Park (2020), and Sun (2020, 2021).

Moreover, I notice that adfocal *mỗi* ‘only’ is mainly used by Northern Vietnamese speakers (e.g., from Hanoi). While my consultants from the South (e.g., from Saigon and Dalat) were able to judge the meaning and acceptability of sentences with *mỗi*, they uniformly reported to me that adfocal *mỗi* sounds *Miền Bắc* ‘Northern’ to them.⁸

Below, I provide a description of *mỗi*’s focus association and syntactic distribution. First, it attaches to the left of a focus. It can associate with DP focus in (25)a-c, including subjects

⁶ This is different from aspect markers like durative *đang*, which *asserts* that there is an event whose runtime includes the reference time interval (cf. Dowty 1979), making truth conditional contribution.

⁷ An example of universal *mỗi* is given below:

- (i) *Mỗi người có một cuốn sách.*
 each person have one CL book
 ‘Each person has one book.’

⁸ It is possible that the adfocal use of *mỗi* results from recent grammatical development initiated by the northern dialect, but further work is needed to examine it.

and objects, but not with VP focus in (25)d.

(25) Association of *mỗi* with focus

a. Christmas-party-5

Mỗi [Linh]_F nói đồng ý. (Subject focus)

PRT.only Linh say agree

‘Only *Linh* said yes.’

b. Christmas-party-7

Nam tặng *mỗi* [túi xách]_F cho cô ấy. (DO focus)

Nam give PRT.only handbag to her

‘Nam only gave *a handbag* to her.’

c. Christmas-party-6

Nam tặng hoa cho *mỗi* [cô ấy]_F. (IO focus)

Nam give flower to PRT.only her

‘Nam gave flowers to only *her*.’

d. Christmas-party-10

*Nam nghĩ mình nên *mỗi* [tặng hoa cho Linh]_F. (*VP focus)

Nam think self should PRT.only give flower to Linh

Int.: ‘Nam thinks he should have only *given flowers to Linh*.’

Second, *mỗi* only occurs at the outermost shell of a DP and cannot be embedded within a DP, as shown in (26). Although the intended focus in (26)b is the NP *tạp chí* ‘magazine’, *mỗi* still cannot occur immediately before it in (26)c.

(26) *Mỗi* occurs at the outermost shell of a DP

a. *Nam (chỉ) đọc mỗi [tạp chí]_F, không đọc sách.*

Nam only read PRT.only magazine, not read book

‘Nam only read *magazines* and did not read books.’

b. *Nam (chỉ) đọc mỗi [mấy quyển [tạp chí]_F này],*

Nam only read PRT.only several CL magazine this

không đọc những quyển sách này.

not read PL CL book this

‘Nam only read these several *magazines* and did not read these books.’

c. *Nam (chỉ) đọc [mấy (*mỗi) quyển (*mỗi) [tạp chí]_F (*mỗi) này],*

Nam only read several PRT.only CL PRT.only magazine PRT.only this

không đọc những quyển sách này.

not read PL CL book this

‘Nam read (only) these several (only) *magazines* and did not read these books.’

Interestingly, *mỗi* cannot occur with the plural marker *những* (for Vietnamese plural markers, see Phan and Chierchia 2022; Cao 2025 and references therein), as in (27). This seems to suggest that *mỗi* and *những* compete for the highest projection on the nominal domain.

(27) **Nam (chỉ) đọc mỗi [những quyển [tạp chí]_F này].*

Nam only read PRT.only PL CL magazine this

Int.: ‘Nam only read these *magazines*.’

Relatedly, I observe that *những* may precede a numeral and occupy the outermost shell of

DP. This use triggers a surprise/“higher than expectation” reading, as in (28), which is rarely discussed in the literature.^{9,10} The “regular” use of *những* preceding classifiers in (29) does not carry this reading.

(28) The “higher-than-expectation” use of plural *những*

[Context: I thought Nam would only read one or even no magazines, but he read several/three.]

Nam đọc [những ba/mấy quyển tạp chí]!

Nam read PL three/several CL magazine

‘Nam read three/several magazines!’ (more than I expected!)

(29) *Nam đọc [những quyển tạp chí]*.

Nam read PL CL magazine

‘Nam read the magazines.’ (no requirement on the expectation)

Third, we turn to prepositional phrases. For the dative-preposition-like *cho* ‘to/give’, *mỗi* must occur after it in (30), adjacent to the DP (i.e., embedded in a PP).

(30) Dative *cho* ‘to’ PP with *mỗi*

*Lan (chỉ) đưa [một cuốn sách] {a. *mỗi} [PP cho {b. mỗi} [Nam]_F].*

Lan only give one CL book PRT.only to PRT.only Nam

‘Lan gave a book {*only} to {only} Nam.’

⁹ It is mentioned in passing by Phan and Lam (2021:12n14) in a footnote, called the “the abundance reading”.

¹⁰ As argued by Hole (2017) and Yip (2026), *mỗi* has a “lower than expectation” scalar inference, which might be a semantic reason why it cannot occur with *những*.

Interestingly, there seems to be some flexibility around other PPs as shown in (31)-(32), resembling English adfocal *only* which can occur before or after the preposition (see Bouma, Hendricks, and Hoeksema 2007 for a corpus study). See also Hole (2008:30n15) for examples with *mỗi* preceding locative PPs headed by *lên* ‘onto’ and *trên* ‘on’. Nevertheless, adjacency to the DP is still preferred in (31)-(32). I focus on DP cases throughout the paper, setting aside the PP cases.¹¹

(31) **Locative ở ‘at’ PP with *mỗi*** ((b) preferred)

Hôm qua Lan (chỉ) làm bài tập {a. mỗi} [PP ở {b. mỗi} thư viện_F].

yesterday Lan only do homework PRT.only at PRT.only library

‘Yesterday, Lan did homework {only} at {only} the library.’

(32) **Temporal trong ‘in’ PP with *mỗi*** ((b) preferred)

Lan (chỉ) làm bài tập {a. mỗi} [PP trong {b. mỗi} tuần này_F].

Lan only do homework PRT.only in PRT.only week this

‘Lan does homework {only} in {only} this week.’

Lastly, *mỗi* can associate with *wh*-nominals as in (33), like adverbial *chỉ*.

¹¹ However, for the temporal preposition *lúc* ‘at’, *mỗi* can only occur outside the whole PP:

(i) **Hôm qua Lan (chỉ) làm bài tập {a. mỗi} [PP lúc {b. *mỗi} 9 giờ sáng].*

yesterday Lan only do homework PRT.only at PRT.only 9 o’clock morning

Int.: ‘Yesterday, Lan did homework at only 9 am (morning).’

It is not surprising given that *lúc* is also a noun meaning ‘moment’; and *mỗi* cannot occur inside a DP/NP. Then, the so-called prepositional use of *lúc* might indeed involve a null preposition: [PP P-Ø [NP *lúc* ...]].

(33) Association of *mǒi* with *wh*-nominals

Nó ǎn mǒi [cái gì]_F?

3SG eat PRT.only what

Lit.: ‘S/he ate only *what?*’ i.e., ‘What is *x* such that s/he ate only *x?*’

I propose that *mǒi* forms a constituent with a full-fledged DP, labeled as QP in (34). I further assume that it requires F-marking of or within its syntactic sister. This is why *mǒi* is always “adfocal” (attaching to a focus).

(34) The syntax of the adfocal particle *mǒi* ‘only’

[_{QP} *mǒi* [_{DP} ... [_{NumP} ... [_{ClP} ... NP]]]]_F

2.3. Sentence-final particle *thôi*

We now turn to the SFP *thôi* ‘only’.¹² Before proceeding, it is important to distinguish it from other non-focus uses, such as those marking imperatives and agreement with concession in (35), which are excluded from the discussion below.

(35) Non-focus uses of *thôi*

a. *Đi thôi!* (imperative)

go SFP

‘Let’s go!’

¹² The SFP *thôi*’s lexical source is the verb *thôi* ‘stop’. Interestingly, *yí* in Mandarin exclusive SFP *éryi* ‘only’ also means ‘stop’ (已) in Archaic Chinese.

b. *Làm thế cũng tốt thôi!* (concessive agreement)

do like.that also good SFP

‘I guess it’s also fine to do it this way.’ (Tran 2015:176)

That *thôi* carries the meaning of ‘only’ is long noticed (e.g., Thompson 1965; Hole 2013), but no systematic study has been conducted. Below, I discuss its focus association, embedding patterns and co-occurrence with other functional elements.

First, *thôi* may associate at a distance with different foci in the VP domain, including the VP itself, as in (36).

(36) Association of *thôi* with focus

a. Christmas-party-7

Nam tặng [túi xách]_F cho cô ấy thôi. (DO focus)

Nam give handbag to her SFP.only

‘Nam only gave a handbag to her.’

b. Christmas-party-6

Nam tặng hoa cho [cô ấy]_F thôi. (IO focus)

Nam give flowers to her SFP.only

‘Nam only gave a handbag to her.’

c. Christmas-party-10

Nam nghĩ mình nên [tặng hoa cho Linh]_F thôi. (VP focus)

Nam think self should give flowers to Linh SFP.only

‘Nam thinks that he should have only given flowers to Linh.’

However, without other particles, *thôi* generally cannot associate with subjects. Speakers

reported that (37)a only has a VP or an object focus reading, even in the context of the storyboard. To achieve subject focus association, adverbial *chỉ*, pre-subject *có* ‘have’, and/or adfocal *mỗi* (which can also co-occur with *chỉ* and/or *có*) are strongly preferred, as in (37)b.

(37)(Non-)association of *thôi* with subjects

a. Christmas-party-5

**[Linh]_F nói đồng ý thôi.* (*Subject focus)

Linh say agree SFP.only

Int.: ‘Only *Linh* said yes.’

b. Christmas-party-5

{Chỉ/ có/ mỗi} [Linh]_F nói đồng ý thôi. (Subject focus)

only have PRT.only Linh say agree SFP.only

‘Only *Linh* said yes.’

For some speakers, the subject focus is improved with a numeral, which facilitates a scalar reading (i.e., “one” is a small number). (38) was natural for a few speakers (6-7/7, n=8), degraded for some others (4-5/7, n=8), and unacceptable for the rest (1-3/7, n=5). With *có* ‘have’, the sentence was perfect for all of them.

(38) [Context: You invited five friends to party. However, only Nam responded. You say: Only one person comes. We should cancel the party!]

a. *%[Một người]_F đến thôi.*

one person come SFP.only

‘Only *one person* comes.’ (mean=4.76/7, SD=1.92, n=21)

b. *Có [một người]_F đến thôi.*

have one person come SFP.only

‘Only *one person* comes.’

Similar variation exists in answers to subject *wh*-questions, which force a subject focus reading as in (39). Again, some speakers found it natural (6-7/7, n=8), but the others either found it degraded (4-5/7, n=7) or unacceptable (1-3/7, n=5), as compared to the natural version with *có*.

(39)[Q: *Ai đến?* ‘Who comes?’]

a. *%[Nam]_F đến thôi.*

Nam come SFP.only

‘Only *Nam* comes.’

(mean=4.85/7, SD=1.7, n=20)

b. *Có [Nam]_F đến thôi.*

have Nam come SFP.only

‘Only *Nam* comes.’

For some speakers, *thôi* can also associate with a moved object in the presence of *chỉ*, as in (41)a (reproduced from (10)). With only *có* in (41)b, however, such association is severely degraded and most speakers reported that only subject focus is available.

(40)a. *%Chỉ (có) [cuốn sách này]_F Nam đọc thôi.* (Moved object focus)

only have CL book this Nam read SFP.only

‘Only *this book*, Nam read.’

(mean=5.08/7, n=12)

b. ??[*Có [cuốn sách này]_F Nam đọc **thôi**]. (*Moved object focus)*

have CL book this Nam read SFP.only

Int.: ‘Only *this book*, Nam read.’ (mean=3.42/7, n=12)

ONLY: ‘This book, only *Nam* read.’

Generally, *thôi* alone cannot associate with a *wh*-word, unless other exclusive particles such as adverbial *chỉ* are present, as in (41).¹³

(41) (Non-)association of *thôi* with *wh*-nominals

*Minh ??(chỉ) ăn [cái gì]_F **thôi**?*

Minh only eat what SFP.only

‘What is the thing *x* such that Minh eats only *x*?’

Second, we turn to embedding. Whether *thôi* can be embedded under CP depends on whether there is doubling with *chỉ*. With *chỉ*, *thôi* may appear in relative clauses, subject clauses, and adverbial clauses in (42)-(44). Without *chỉ*, embedded *thôi* was at least degraded and even unacceptable for some speakers.

¹³ I have no explanation to the difference in association with *wh*, but such contrasts are also found in other East Asian and Southeast languages, including Cantonese and Mandarin (Yip 2026), as well as Thai (between adfocal *khêe* and SFP *thâwnán*; Yip & Manowang 2026).

(42) **Embedding *thôi* in relative clauses**

[*Học sinh mà ??(chỉ) đọc sách [tiếng Anh]_F thôi*]

student REL only read book English SFP.only

(*thì*) không thích giáo viên đó.

TOP NEG like teacher that

‘The student who only reads *English* books doesn’t like that teacher.’

(*thôi*: mean=4.6/7,SD=1.39,n=20)

(*chỉ...thôi*: mean=6.45/7,SD=0.89,n=20)

(43) **Embedding *thôi* in subject clauses**

[*Việc (mà) Nam ??(chỉ) đọc [một]_F cuốn sách thôi*]

fact REL Nam only read one CL book SFP.only

làm tôi ngạc nhiên.

make 1SG surprised

‘The fact that Nam read only *one* book surprised me.’

(*thôi*: mean=5.1/7,SD=1.21,n=20)

(*chỉ...thôi*: mean=6.7/7,SD=0.73,n=20)

(44) **Embedding *thôi* in adverbial clauses**

[*Nếu con ??(chỉ) ăn [thịt bò]_F thôi*],

if 2SG only eat beef SFP.only

thì mẹ sẽ đánh con.

TOP mother FUT hit 2SG

‘If you only eat *beef*, your mum will beat you up.’

(*thôi*: mean=5.1/7,SD=1.59,n=20)

(*chỉ...thôi*: mean=6.8/7,SD=0.83,n=20)

Third, we examine *thôi*'s co-occurrence with other functional heads, including SFPs and preverbal heads. Sentence-final modal *được* 'can', which has a root modal flavor (circumstantial/abilitative), occurs lower in the structure (e.g., below T, see Duffield 1999; Simpson 2001; Simpson and Pham 2026; Trang Phan 2023).¹⁴ *Thôi* must follow *được*, as shown in (45).

(45) ***Thôi* follows sentence-final modal *được***

a. Ông Quang mua [một]_F cái điện thoại được *thôi*.

Mr. Quang buy one CL phone can SFP.only

‘Quang could only buy *one* mobile phone.’

b. *Ông Quang mua một cái điện thoại *thôi* được.

Mr. Quang buy one CL phone SFP.only can

When we move to higher elements such as tense markers (at T), interestingly, *thôi* cannot occur with *đã* in (46).

(46) ***Thôi* cannot co-occur with past tense *đã***

*Nam đã mua [sách]_F *thôi*.

Nam PST buy book SFP.only

Int.: ‘Nam only bought *books*.’

As shown in (47), *thôi* also cannot co-occur with the sentence-final perfect marker *rồi* ‘already’ (for *rồi*, see Le 2014; Trang Phan 2023), which often co-occurs with *đã*.

¹⁴ *Được* has variable positions, including preverbal, postverbal (suffixal), and sentence-final positions, which yield different modal flavors. See the citations above.

(47) ***Thôi* cannot co-occur with aspectual SFP *rồi***

a. **Nam mua [sách]_F rồi thôi.*

Nam buy book already SFP.only

b. **Nam mua [sách]_F **thôi** rồi.*

Nam buy book SFP.only already

(a-b): Int.: ‘Nam already only bought *books*.’

With regard to the SFPs above CP, surprisingly, *thôi* displays flexibility in preceding or following them. It is necessary to bring out some background on the cartography of SFPs in Vietnamese first. Le (2014) proposes the following cartographic structure of SFPs in Vietnamese (cf. Nguyen 2021a; Trần Phan 2024):

(48) **The cartography of SFPs in Vietnamese (Le 2014)**

DiscourseP > MoodP > DeikP (for demonstrative SFPs) > ForceP (=CP) > TP

The demonstrative SFP *đấy* comes from the demonstrative *đấy* ‘that’. As an SFP, it emphatically asserts the proposition and brings out a sense of “persuading” the addressee, as in (49) (Nguyen 2021a, 2021b). As illustrated in the naturalistic examples collected by Vo (2012) in (50), *thôi* may precede *đấy* and take narrow scope under it. Surprisingly, it can also follow *đấy*.

(49) *Việc này nguy hiểm đấy.*

job this dangerous SFP

‘Believe me, this job is dangerous.’

(Nguyen 2021b:119)

(50) *Thôi* may precede or follow SFP *đầy*

a. *Đến tôi đây quần quật suốt ngày,*

even I here toil whole day

*đã ốm cả xác mà cũng chỉ được có [ba]_F lưng **thôi** đầy ...*

PST sick exhausted MA also only get have three back SFP.only SFP

‘Even if I worked hard for a whole day and ruined my body, I still only got *three* bowls.’

b. *Ấy tôi chỉ được có bốn sóc cua hai xu*

INTERJ I only get have four basket crab two cent

*với một mẻ tôm riu năm xu là [bảy]_F đầy **thôi**.*

with one tray shrimp small five cent COP seven SFP SFP.only

‘I only earned two cents for four crabs, five cents for a bunch of shrimps, and in total just *seven* cents.’

(Vo 2012:129)

Consider another high SFP at MoodP, *mà* (Le 2014, Trần Phan 2024). It usually reconfirms a fact that is previously known but it is not clear whether addressee believes it, as exemplified in (51).

(51) *Anh ấy biết e-mail của chị **mà**.*

he know e-mail of yours SFP.

‘(As you know), he knows your email.’ (Felicitous in a context where the listener believes that a third person does not know their email)

(Le 2014:78)

Again, *thôi* may either precede or follow *mà*, as in the naturalistic examples in (52).¹⁵

(52) *Thôi* may precede or follow SFP *mà*

a. *Tôi làm trong [chớp mắt]_F là xong thôi mà.*

1SG do in blink eye COP finish SFP.only SFP

‘I finished it just in *the blink of an eye*.’

b. *Trước kia cha thương mẹ chín,*

before time father love mother nine

mười thì bây giờ chỉ còn [bốn năm]_F mà thôi.

ten TOP now only remain four five SFP SFP.only

‘In the past, father loved mother nine or ten out of ten; now it’s only *four or five*.’

(Vo 2012:101,130)

Note that the word order between *đấy mà* is fixed: *đấy* must precede *mà* (Le 2014; Trần Phan p.c.), so we know that it is *thôi* that has flexible word order, but not the other two SFPs.

As for the outermost elements like tag question marker *phải không* ‘right?’, *thôi* can only precede it in (53):

(53) *Thôi* precedes question tag *phải không*

a. *Bạn có [hai]_F quyển sách thôi phải không?*

2SG have two CL book SFP.only right not

‘You only have *two* books, right?’

¹⁵ Trần Phan (p.c.) pointed out to me that in *mà thôi*, the meaning of *mà* changes when *thôi* is dropped. It is possible that *mà thôi* has become a compound SFP (which is also attested in Cantonese, Wong 2014; Tang 2015). Yet, *đấy thôi* remains compositional and is an SFP cluster. I thank Trần Phan for the insightful observations.

- b. **Bạn có [hai]_F quyển sách phải không thôi?*

2SG have two CL book right not SFP.only

Summarizing, there appears to be conflicting evidence for *thôi*'s syntactic position. Some patterns suggest that it should be low in the structure, such as within TP, as in (54); whereas other data suggest that it should be higher than CP, as in (55).

(54) Indicators of *thôi*'s low position

a. *Focus association*

Cannot associate with subject focus in singleton *thôi* cases. → within TP

b. *Embedding*

Can be embedded under relative, subject, and adverbial clauses when doubled with *chỉ*

→ within CP

c. *Co-occurrence with other functional elements*

(i) May precede demonstrative SFPs and Mood SFPs → lower than DeikP, e.g., on CP

(ii) Incompatible with tense markers and SFPs → at T or below

(55) Indicators of *thôi*'s high position

a. *Focus association*

Can associate with subject focus and even moved object focus (for some speakers) with other particles → above TP or CP

b. *Embedding*

Cannot be readily embedded under relative, subject, and adverbial clauses in singleton *thôi* cases → above CP

c. *Co-occurrence with other functional elements*

May follow demonstrative SFPs and Mood SFPs → higher than MoodP

To resolve the conflicting patterns, I propose that *thôi* has two positions: the outer one is higher than CP, and the inner one is lower than TP, as in (56) (head directionality ignored).¹⁶

I label *thôi*'s projection as FP, where F means “focus-related”; and I reserve the label Foc(us)P for the host of focus movement (see §4).

(56) **The syntax of the SFP *thôi* ‘only’**

[DiscourseP ... [FP-outer *thôi* [MoodP ... [DeikP ... [ForceP/CP ... [TP ... [FP-inner *thôi* [AspP ...

The inner *thôi* cannot associate with subjects, and may be embedded. It is located in-between Asp and T, blocking head movement of *đã* from Asp to T, and hence the ban on the co-occurrence. The outer *thôi*, on the other hand, can associate with the subjects and cannot be embedded. It also follows high SFPs at the periphery, such as demonstrative and mood SFPs.

That *thôi* has two positions is reminiscent of Tang's (2006) discussion of Cantonese SFP *sin1* ‘(lit.) first’, which has an inner use of expressing event order (in the vP domain) and an outer use of modifying speech acts (above CP, e.g., in interrogatives with a sense of “you tell me the answer first”). They can even co-occur, as in (57).

¹⁶ The head directionality of Vietnamese SFP is orthogonal to the current study. See Duffield (2013) for an influential head-initial view, and Trần Phan (2023) for a recent overview.

(57) **The inner and outer SFPs *sin1* in Cantonese**

[[*Keoi sik sin1*] *mei6 sin1*]?

3SG eat SFP SFP SFP

‘(Answer me first:) has s/he eaten first?’

(Tang 2006:230)

It is also not rare to have focus-related projections in clause-external and clause-internal positions, such as focus at the “low” periphery and “high” periphery in Italian (Rizzi 1997; Belletti 2004), ‘even’-focus in Cantonese and Mandarin (Badan and Del Gobbo 2015; Cheung 2015), and object focalization in Mandarin (e.g., Chen 2023), etc.¹⁷

3. Locality and intervention in exclusive doubling

After clarifying the syntax of exclusive particles, this section focuses on their doubling. I contrast AdFoc Doubling (*chǐ* ... *mǒi*) and SFP Doubling (*chǐ* ... *thô*) in locality effects (§3.1) and intervention by quantificational elements (§3.2).

3.1. Asymmetries in locality effects

Consider AdFoc Doubling first. When *mǒi* is embedded, it is ambiguous between a narrow scope reading and a wide scope reading, as in (58) with a nonfinite clause taken by *bǎt* ‘force’. (See Taglicht 1984 for similar facts of adfocal *only* in English.) To disambiguate, adverbial *chǐ* may be added to the corresponding scope positions. When *chǐ* is in the matrix clause as in (58)b, we obtain a configuration of long-distance doubling across nonfinite clause boundaries.

¹⁷ From a Minimalist perspective, the two positions may reflect two phase edges in the clausal domain: the CP phase edge and the vP phase edge (see Erlewine 2017b for SFPs in the two edges in Mandarin).

(58) **AdFoc doubling across nonfinite TP boundaries**

a. *Thầy giáo bắt Nam [(chỉ) học mỗi [tiếng Pháp]_F].*

teacher force Nam only study PRT.only French

(Không được học tiếng Anh.)

not may study English

‘The teacher forces John to only take *French*.’ (Cannot study English)

(Narrow scope: force>only)

b. *Thầy giáo (chỉ) bắt Nam [học mỗi [tiếng Pháp]_F].*

teacher only force Nam study PRT.only French

(Không bắt Nam học tiếng Anh).

not force Nam study English

‘The teacher only forces John to take *French*.’ (Doesn’t force Nam to study English)

(Wide scope: only>force)

Exclusive doubling is possible across finite CP boundaries as well, as shown in (59)b with a matrix verb *biết* ‘know’, as compared to (59)a where the doubling is local. For some speakers, the long-distance doubling is more accessible with typical bridge verbs like *nghĩ* ‘think’ (Tue Trinh p.c.).

(59) **AdFoc doubling across finite CP boundaries**

a. *Thầy giáo biết* [_{CP} *là Nam (chỉ) học mỗi* [*tiếng Pháp*]_F]

teacher know COMP Nam only study PRT.only French

(và *biết Nam không học tiếng Anh*).

and know Nam not study English

‘The teacher knows that Nam only took *French* (, and knows that Nam didn’t take English.)’

(Narrow scope: know>only)

b. *Thầy giáo (chỉ) biết* [_{CP} *là Nam học mỗi* [*tiếng Pháp*]_F]

teacher only know COMP Nam study PRT.only French

(*không biết Nam có học tiếng Anh*).

not know Nam have study English

‘The teacher only knows that Nam took *French* (, and doesn’t know that Nam took English.)’

(Wide scope: only>know)

Wide scope of *mỗi* is blocked across a syntactic island. In (60), *mỗi* is embedded in a complex NP island of a noun complement clause. Now, the wide scope reading of *mỗi* is unavailable in (60)a—it must be interpreted in the island, as indicated by the infelicitous continuation which is only compatible with a wide scope reading. If adverbial *chỉ* is added to the matrix clause as in (60)b, a multiple-‘only’ reading is obtained instead (with two exclusive operators interpreted).

(60) **AdFoc doubling is banned across complex NP islands**

a. *Thầy giáo biết* [_{DP} *tin* [_{CP} *Nam học mỗi* [_{tiếng Pháp}_F]]]

teacher know news Nam study PRT.only French

(#*không biết Nam có học tiếng Anh*).

not know Nam have study English

‘The teacher knows the news that Nam only took *French* (#but doesn’t know that Nam took English).’ (Narrow scope: know>only)

b. *Thầy giáo chỉ biết* [_{DP} *tin* [_{CP} *Nam học mỗi* [_{tiếng Pháp}_F]]]

teacher only know news Nam study PRT.only French

(#*không biết Nam có học tiếng Anh*).

not know Nam have study English

ONLY: ‘The teacher only knows the news that Nam only took French (#but doesn’t know whether Nam took English).’ (Multi-‘only’: only>know>only)

BUT NOT: ‘The teacher only knows the news that Nam took *French* (but doesn’t know that Nam took English).’ (Wide scope: only>know)

Moreover, a coordination structure also blocks the doubling, as illustrated below. In (61)a, *mỗi* cannot be placed in the second conjunct. Interestingly, *mỗi* also cannot be placed in both conjuncts in (61)b. Anticipating an analysis that in-situ *mỗi* undergoes covert focus movement, (61)b indicates the absence of covert across-the-board (ATB) movement (as also argued by Bošković & Franks 2000). Note that while *mỗi* may precede the first conjunct in (61)c, what it associates with is the whole coordinated DP, as evidenced by the available reading.

(61) **AdFoc Doubling banned across coordinated DP**

- a. **Nam chỉ ăn* [*[DP1 sushi]* và *[DP2 mới* [pizza]_F]].

Nam only eat sushi and PRT.only pizza

Int.: ‘Nam ate sushi and only *pizza* (among Italian food).’

- b. **Nam chỉ ăn* [*[DP1 mới* [sushi]_F] và *[DP2 mới* [pizza]_F]].

Nam only eat PRT.only sushi and PRT.only pizza

Int.: ‘Nam ate only *sushi* (among Japanese food) and only *pizza* (among Italian food).’

- c. *Nam chỉ ăn mới* [*[DP1 sushi]* và *[DP2 pizza]*]_F.

Nam only eat PRT.only sushi and pizza

ONLY: ‘The only things Nam ate are *sushi and pizza*.’

NOT: ‘Nam ate only *sushi* (among Japanese food) and pizza.’

Turning to SFP Doubling, the long-distance test requires a baseline with matrix indirect object placed after embedded CP, as in (62). While this word order is marked (cf. the default V-IO-CP order), it is acceptable for almost all of my consultants.

(62) **Baseline: Association with embedded DO with a V-CP-IO word order**

- a. *Kim chỉ nói* [_{CP} là *Mai đọc* [tiểu thuyết]_F] với thầy giáo.

Kim only say COMP Mai read novel to teacher

‘Kim only told the teacher that Mai read *novels* (and didn’t say that Mai also read textbooks).’

(Wide scope: only>say)

(mean=6.5/7, SD=0.92, n=18)

b. *Kim nói [CP là Mai **chỉ** đọc [tiểu thuyết]_F] với thầy giáo.*

Kim say COMP Mai only read novel to teacher

‘Kim told the teacher that Mai only read *novels* (and also said that Mai didn’t read textbooks).’

(Narrow scope: say>only)

(mean=6.39/7,SD=0.92,n=18)

We now place *thôi* in the matrix clause with an embedded DO focus. As shown in (63)a, it is possible for most speakers under a wide scope reading (only>say). Some speakers (n=5, out of 18) got a matrix IO focus reading, which is irrelevant for the discussion and is excluded for examining exclusive doubling. (63)b adds *chỉ* in the embedded clause. Importantly, most speakers (n=10, out of 13) reported a multi-‘only’ reading (only>say>only), instead of a “doubled/concord” reading with only one exclusive operator interpreted (say>only). In other words, SFP Doubling cannot be applied across a finite CP boundary.

(63) SFP Doubling is banned across finite CPs

a. *Kim nói [CP là Mai đọc [tiểu thuyết]_F] với thầy giáo **thôi**.*

Kim say COMP Mai read novels to teacher SFP.only

ONLY: ‘Kim only told the teacher that Mai read *novels*.’

(Wide scope: only>say)

(mean=5/7,SD=2.43,n=18)

NOT: ‘Kim told the teacher that Mai only read *novels*.’

(Narrow scope: say>only)

(mean=2.56/7,SD=1.7,n=18)

b. *Kim nói [CP là Mai **chỉ** đọc [tiểu thuyết]_F] với thầy giáo **thôi**.*

Kim say COMP Mai only read novels to teacher SFP.only

ONLY: ‘Kim only said *this* to the teacher, which is that Mai only read *novels*.’

(Multi-‘only’: only>say>only)

Interestingly, SFP Doubling is possible across coordinated VPs in (64), which are sub-clausal islands. *Chỉ* may be placed in the second conjunct in (64)a or in both conjuncts in (64)b, and doubled with *thôi* outside. Notice that *thôi* is not part of the second conjunct. (65) shows that *thôi* cannot be embedded in coordinated VPs unless there are pauses between the VPs, which are absent in (64).¹⁸

(64) SFP Doubling across coordinated structures

a. *Nam [[VP ăn gà rán] và [VP **chỉ** uống [cô ca]_F]] **thôi**.*

Nam eat fried.chicken and only drink coke SFP.only

‘Nam ate fried chicken and only drank *coke*.’

b. *Nam [[VP **chỉ** ăn [gà rán]_F] và [VP **chỉ** uống [cô ca]_F]] **thôi**.*

Nam only eat fried.chicken and only drink coke SFP.only

‘Nam only ate *fried chicken* and only drank *coke*.’

¹⁸ In SFP Doubling, *chỉ* cannot be placed in the first conjunct which is further away from *thôi*, as in (i). This restriction is reminiscent of closest conjunct agreement (Nevins and Weisser 2019).

(i) *Nó **chỉ** [[ăn gà rán] và [uống cô ca]]_F **thôi**.*

3SG only eat fried.chicken and drink coke SFP.only

ONLY: ‘The only thing s/he did was to *eat fried chicken and drink coke*.’

NOT: ‘S/he only ate *fried chicken*; and drank coke.’

(65) *Nó [chỉ ăn gà rán **thôi**] ?(l) và ?(l) [chỉ uống cô ca **thôi**].*

3SG only eat fried.chicken SFP.only and only drink coke SFP.only

‘S/he only ate *fried chicken* and only drank *coke*.’

3.2. Asymmetries in intervention effects

We now discuss intervention by quantificational elements such as negation and modals.

With a modal, *mỗi* is scopally ambiguous in (66), which may be disambiguated by the placement of *chỉ* (see also Sun 2020). The wide scope case in (66)c shows that AdFoc

Doubling across modals is possible. That is, modals do not trigger intervention effects (IEs).

(66) AdFoc Doubling with modals

[i. Context for narrow scope: This is Nam’s graduation day. Although everyone is supposed to bring at least two drinks, Nam is the one who graduates so he is free from this limitation. You know that Nam likes wine.]

[ii. Context for wide scope: This is a wine tasting day. Everyone must bring wine. No other alcohols are allowed. You know Nam will attend the event.]

a. *Nam có thể mang **mỗi** [rượu vang]_F.*

Nam may bring PRT.only wine

i. ‘It is allowed that Nam only brings *wine*.’ (though he can also bring other alcohols)

(◊>only)

ii. ‘Nam can only bring *wine*.’ (he cannot bring whisky etc.)

(only>◊)

b. *Nam có thể **chỉ** mang **mỗi** [rượu vang]_F.*

Nam may only bring PRT.only wine

i. It is allowed that Nam only brings *wine*.’

(◊>only)

c. Nam *chỉ có thể mang mỗi* [rượu vang]_F.

Nam only may bring only wine

ii. ‘Nam can only bring wine.’ (only>◊)

Then consider negation. While AdFoc Doubling below negation is possible in (67), it is also attested across a negation in (68). No IEs are triggered.

(67) AdFoc Doubling with negation: Narrow scope

Christmas-party-8

Nam *không chỉ tặng túi xách cho mỗi* [cô ấy]_F.

Nam not only give handbag to PRT.only her

‘Nam did not only give a handbag to *her* (but he also gave one to another girl, Giang).’

(¬>only)

(68) AdFoc Doubling with negation: Wide scope

Nam *chỉ không học mỗi* [tiếng Pháp]_F.

Nam only not learn PRT.only French

‘Nam only does not learn *French* (i.e., He learnt all other languages).’ (only>¬)

As for SFP Doubling, negation has an opposite behavior. As shown in (69), while *chỉ* may take narrow scope, *thôi* alone cannot (only wide scope is possible), meaning that *thôi* is higher than the negation. Importantly, *chỉ...thôi* doubling across negation is not possible. Note that *thôi* is an SFP so intervention is not obvious from the word order, but hierarchically *không* is in-between *chỉ* and *thôi* in (69)c.

(69) IEs of negation in SFP Doubling

a. Christmas-party-8

Nam [không chỉ tặng túi xách cho [cô ấy]_F].

Nam not only give handbag to her

‘Nam did not only give a handbag to *her*.’ (mean=7/7,SD=0,n=20)

b. Christmas-party-8

#Nam [không tặng túi xách cho [cô ấy]_F] thôi.

Nam not give handbag to her SFP.only

Int.: ‘Nam did not only give a handbag to *her*.’ (mean=1.7/7,SD=1.38,n=20)

c. Christmas-party-8

**Nam [không chỉ tặng túi xách cho [cô ấy]_F] thôi.*

Nam not only give handbag to her SFP.only

Int.: ‘Nam did not only give a handbag to *her*.’ (mean=3.15/7,SD=2.56,n=20)

Now consider modals. Permission modals like *có thể* ‘may’ also induce IEs. Again, *thôi* cannot have the narrow scope reading in (70)b, and SFP Doubling with *chỉ* across the modal is banned in (70)c.

(70) IEs of modals in SFP Doubling

a. *Nam [có thể chỉ học [tiếng Pháp]_F].*

Nam may only learn French

Int.: ‘It is allowed that Nam only learns French.’ (i.e., Nam may also learn German)

b. *#Nam [có thể học [tiếng Pháp]_F] thôi.*

Nam may learn French SFP.only

Int.: ‘It is allowed that Nam only learns *French*.’

c. **Nam* [*có thể* ***chỉ*** *học* [*tiếng Pháp*]_F] ***thôi***.

Nam may only learn French SFP.only

Int.: ‘It is allowed that Nam only learns *French*.’

This contrasts with cases where the modals appear lower than *chỉ* in (71). *Có thể* ‘may’ is simply too low to intervene.

(71) *Nam* [***chỉ*** *có thể* *học* [*tiếng Pháp*]_F] ***thôi***.

Nam only may learn French SFP.only

‘Nam can only learn French.’ (i.e., Nam cannot learn German)

Turning to quantificational adverbs like *bình thường* ‘usually’, interestingly, no IEs are observed in (72). For some speakers, *thôi* had narrow scope only when doubled with *chỉ*, and other speakers allowed *thôi* alone for narrow scope.

(72) No IEs by quantificational adverbs in SFP Doubling

a. *Nó* *bình thường* ***chỉ*** *ăn* [*thịt*]_F.

3SG usually only eat meat

‘S/he usually only eats *meat*.’ (usually>only)

b. *Nó* *bình thường* %(***chỉ***) *ăn* [*thịt*]_F ***thôi***.

3SG usually only eat meat SFP.only

Int.: ‘S/he usually only eats *meat*.’ (usually>only)

While this seems surprising, if we assume that *bình thường* ‘usually’ attaches to TP for quantifying over time, the lack of IEs can be explained by its higher position than the inner

thôi below TP. That is, the structure of (72)b should be like (73), where no interveners are present between *thôi* and *chỉ*. For speakers who require doubling for narrow scope, I assume that an outer *thôi* is parsed in the singleton case, which is higher than *bình thường*.

(73) [TP ... *bình thường* ‘usually’ [FP-inner *thôi* ... [*chỉ* ... VP ...

Quantifier subjects like *không có ai* ‘no one; (lit.) not have who’ also do not trigger IEs, as in (74). For most speakers, doubling with *chỉ* is required for narrow scope with *thôi*.

(74) No IEs by negative quantifier ‘no one’ in SFP Doubling

a. *Không có ai chỉ nộp [một]_F bản tóm tắt.*

NEG have who only submit one CL summary

(*mỗi người đều nộp hai bản*).

every person DEU submit two CL

‘No one only submits one abstract—everyone submits two.’

b. *Không có ai [**(chỉ)* nộp [một]_F bản tóm tắt *thôi**].

NEG have who only submit one CL summary SFP.only

‘No one only submits *one* abstract.’

Again, we may explain the lack of IEs by analyzing the occurrence of *thôi* as at an inner position. It is lower than SpecTP, where the quantifier subjects stay.

(75) [TP Q-subject [T [FP-inner *thôi* ... [*chỉ* ... VP ...

3.3. Interim summary

In sum, there are two asymmetries between the two types of exclusive doubling. The first one is in locality. AdFoc Doubling may cross CP boundaries in a long-distance fashion, but not island boundaries. In contrast, SFP Doubling must be local in a CP, but it can apply across (sub-clausal) islands. The second asymmetry is in intervention. Quantificational elements trigger IEs only to SFP Doubling but not AdFoc Doubling. The patterns are summarized in Table 1.

Table 1. Asymmetries in locality and intervention effects in Vietnamese exclusive doubling

Properties	AdFoc Doubling	SFP Doubling
Across CP boundaries	✓	✗
Across syntactic islands	✗	✓
IEs by negation	✗	✓
IEs by modals	✗	✓

4. A syntactic account

Given the asymmetries in locality and intervention effects, I argue that the two types of exclusive doubling are formed by different syntactic dependencies. In a nutshell, I propose that AdFoc Doubling involves (c)overt movement triggered by focus [FOC] features (§4.1), whereas SFP Doubling involves Agree with exclusive [EXCL] features (§4.2).

4.1. AdFoc Doubling as (c)overt movement

As seen in §3.1, *chỉ...mỗi* doubling is sensitive to islands, even when *mỗi* is in-situ. This is a signature property of movement (Ross 1967). Indeed, *mỗi* and its focus associates can be ex-situ, as shown in (7) and in (76) below (*mới* ‘just’ is obligatory after movement, Hole

2017; Tran and Zimmermann 2021). Its landing site is argued to be either on a Scal(ar)P (Hole 2017) or Foc(us)P (Sun 2021).

(76) *Nam chi mõi [thịt bò]_F mới ăn _.*

Nam only PRT.only beef just eat

‘Only *beef* does Nam eat.’

(Hole 2017:394)

As for in-situ *mõi*, unlike Hole’s (2017) and Quek and Hirsch’s (2017) Agree-only analysis, I argue that covert movement takes place to the same landing site, labeled as FocP.¹⁹ Nevertheless, I follow their insights that only *chi*, but not *mõi*, is semantically an exclusive operator (i.e., the operator-particle approach; e.g., Y. Lee 2005; Sun 2021; Branen and Erlewine 2023).²⁰ There is also a null counterpart of *chi*, OP_{EXCL}, responsible for the exclusive semantics in singleton *mõi* cases. The featural composition is proposed below:

(77) The featural composition

a. *mõi*: [*u*EXCL:_, *u*FOC:_]

b. Foc⁰: [*u*EXCL:_, *i*FOC:+, EPP]

c. *chi*/OP_{EXCL}: [*i*EXCL:+]

Mõi carries both uninterpretable [*u*FOC] and [*u*EXCL], the former of which is valued by Foc⁰ with interpretable [*i*FOC] and movement-triggering [EPP]. Foc⁰ also carries [*u*EXCL],

¹⁹ The main reason of not labeling the landing site as ScalP is because *mới*, argued to be Scal⁰ by Hole (2017), is not (and cannot be) present in in-situ *mõi* cases. One can, of course, still take the ScalP analysis and assumes that Scal⁰ is null when the movement is covert.

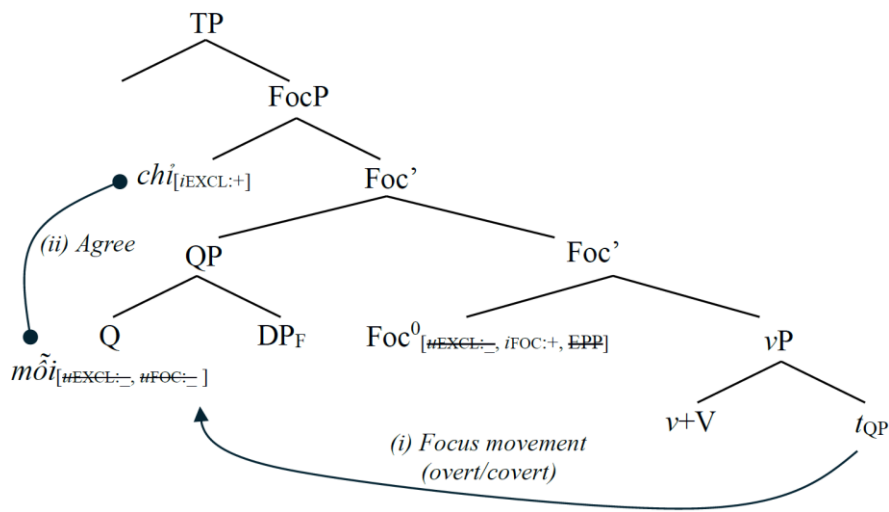
²⁰ Yet, I suggest that *mõi* is not semantically vacuous. It is a scalar operator that depends on an exclusive operator (cf. Hole 2017). For space reasons, readers are referred to Yip (2026) for detailed arguments.

which, along with $m\tilde{o}i$'s $[uEXCL]$, is valued locally by chi/OP_{EXCL} with interpretable $[iEXCL]$.

In other words, there are two dependencies involved in AdFoc Doubling: (i) movement triggered by $[FOC]$, and (ii) Agree triggered by $[EXCL]$. A syntactic derivation is given below.

Note that I assume with Baker (2008) that Agree can be downward or upward (see Zeilstra 2012 for Upward Agree in negative concord), and $m\tilde{o}i$ agrees upward here.

(78) The syntactic derivation of AdFoc Doubling



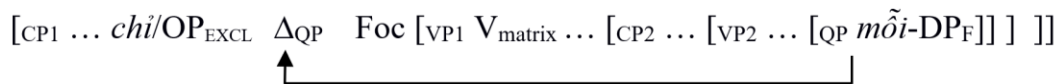
I also assume that both overt and covert movement occur in Narrow Syntax, and the copies may be pronounced in the highest position (overt) or the lowest (covert) (Bošković and Nunes 2007). The latter case is comparable to covert *wh*-movement in *wh*-in-situ languages like Coptic Egyptian (Reintges 2007) or Mongolian (Fong 2019). The locality effects in in-situ $m\tilde{o}i$ cases follow. $M\tilde{o}i$'s narrow scope involves local movement, whereas its wide scope across finite CP boundaries involves long-distance covert focus movement (see also Erlewine and Kotek 2018), which is blocked across island boundaries.

(79) **No wide scope reading across islands**

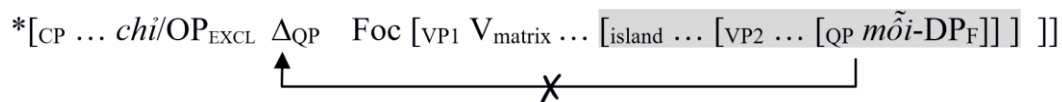
a. *Narrow scope* ($V_{\text{matrix}} > \text{only}$)



b. *Wide scope* ($\text{only} > V_{\text{matrix}}$)



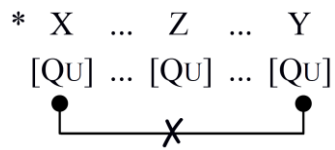
(80) **No wide scope reading across islands**



This proposal improves Sun's (2021) analysis. She assumes that *chi* is at Foc^0 . To derive the fact that *môi* must land below *chi* (as observed in overt movement, see also Erlewine 2017a:332), she adopts a counter-cyclic operation, Undermerge, which Internally Merges an element as a complement, enforcing the original complement to be a specifier (Pesetsky 2013). Undermerge, however, violates the Extension Condition (Chomsky 1995). As argued in §2.1, *chi* should be analyzed as an adjunct instead of a head, which prevents this problem. The obligatoriness of movement and the locality between *chi* and *môi* are explained by the dual encoding of $[u\text{EXCL}]$ and $[u\text{FOC}]$.

Moreover, the current proposal also accounts for the lack of IEs, which is not explained by previous proposals. As we will see below, it follows from the dual encoding of $[u\text{EXCL}]$ and $[u\text{FOC}]$ too. First, I adopt Rizzi's (2001, 2004) feature-based Relativized Minimality, which attributes IEs to a minimality violation of intervening elements carrying the same superfeature (e.g., $[Q\text{U}]$ for quantification and focus) as the dependency type.

(81) Feature-based Relativized Minimality



Second, I refine Rizzi's inventory of superfeatures, crucially separating [FOC] from [QU] (cf. evidence from Cantonese universal concord by Yip 2022 and verb doubling by T. T.-M. Lee 2024), as in (82). [FOC] is on elements that trigger alternatives, while [QU] is on elements with quantificational force, such as [QU:EXCL] for *chỉ*, [QU:NEG] for negation, and [QU:MODAL] for modals.

(82) The proposed superfeatures in Vietnamese

- a. [A]: [D] (cf. Lee and Yip 2024; Phan and Chou 2025)
- b. [QU]: *Wh*-adverbs, Neg, measure, focus operators, modals, quantified DPs, ...
- c. [FOC]: *Wh*-nominals (cf. Tsai 2009), focus associates, doubled verbs, ...
- d. [MOD]: evaluative, epistemic, Neg, frequentative, celerative, measure, manner, ...
- e. [TOP]: topics

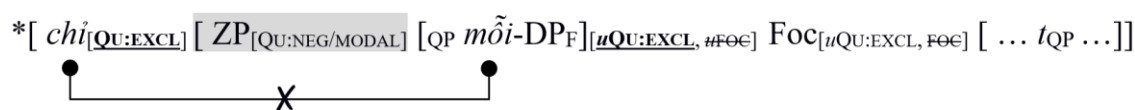
Now, the lack of IEs on the movement path of *mỏi* falls out: it forms a focus dependency with Foc, and [QU] elements like negation and modals do not trigger IEs to it. *Chỉ* only agrees with *mỏi* in [QU:EXCL] after movement. In contrast, proposals that derive *mỏi*'s dependency solely by [QU:EXCL] (e.g., [ONLY] in Quek & Hirsch 2017; Sun 2021) cannot explain the (non-)intervention pattern.

(83) **No IEs by [QU] elements on focus movement path** (Wide scope over NEG/MODAL)



Acute readers might notice an additional prediction from the current proposal: [QU] elements may trigger IEs if they are in-between *chỉ* and the *landing site* of *mỗi* (vs. the launching site), because they form a quantificational dependency.

(84) **Prediction: IEs by [QU] elements** (Wide scope over NEG/MODAL)



While it is not testable with covert movement, this prediction is borne out with overt movement. As shown in (85), *mỗi* must move across the negation immediately below *chỉ*, and IEs are triggered by negation if it intervenes between the moved *mỗi* and *chỉ*.

(85) a. *Nam chỉ [QP mỗi [tiếng Anh]_F] mới không nói* __.

Nam only PRT.only English just not speak

‘Nam only does not speak English. (He speaks German and Vietnamese.)’ (only>¬)

b. **Nam chỉ không [QP mỗi [tiếng Anh]_F] (mới) nói* __.

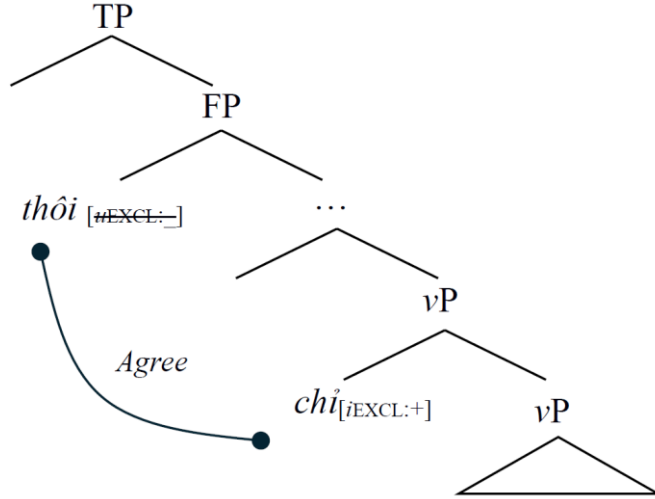
Nam only not PRT.only English just speak

4.2. SFP Doubling as syntactic Agree

As for SFP Doubling, I propose that it involves syntactic Agree in [EXCL] only, without movement triggered by [FOC], similar to SFP Doubling in Cantonese and Mandarin (Yip 2025). *Thôi* carries uninterpretable [EXCL] which agrees (downward) with *chỉ*, as illustrated

in (86) with inner *thôi*.²¹

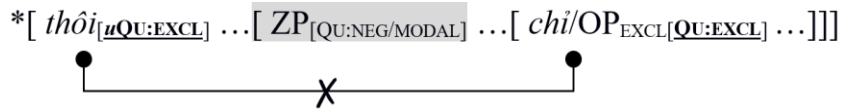
(86) The syntactic derivation of SFP Doubling



First, the IEs between *chỉ* and *thôi* in doubling follow straightforwardly from Relativized Minimality. The lack of narrow scope of singleton *thôi* is also explained: assuming that *thôi* is not the exclusive operator, the null OP_{EXCL} is merged for Agree in [EXCL]. If it is merged below the modals or negation (i.e., narrow scope), IEs will arise; so it can only be merged above them, giving rise to the wide scope.

(87) IEs by [QU] elements in SFP Doubling

a. Narrow scope under NEG/MODAL



b. Wide scope above NEG/MODAL



²¹ In subject focus cases, *chỉ* is attached to TP with which outer *thôi* above CP agrees.

Second, the locality effects also follow from the Agree-only analysis. I assume that Agree is subject to the Phase Impenetrability Condition (Chomsky 2000):

(88) Phase Impenetrability Condition

$[_{XP} X \dots [_{HP=\alpha} [H YP]]]$

In a phase α with head H, the domain of H is not accessible to operations outside α , only

H and its edge are accessible to such operations. (Chomsky 2000:108)

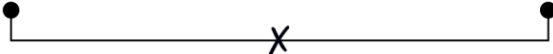
(i.e., YP is visible to operations in HP but not XP)

Since finite CP is a phase, Agree cannot apply across it, and hence the failure of long-distance SFP Doubling. On the other hand, Agree can apply across a non-phasal island boundary (J.-C. Lee 2006), as attested in closest conjunct agreement (e.g., Nevins and Weisser 2019, Shen 2021) and adjunct control implemented as Agree (Fischer & Høyem 2022).

(89) Locality effects in SFP Doubling

a. *Failure of long-distance SFP Doubling across phases*

* $[_{CP1} \dots th\hat{o}i_{[uQU:EXCL]} \dots [V_{matrix} [_{CP2=phase} [_{TP} \dots [chi/OP_{EXCL[QU:EXCL]} \dots]]]]$



b. *SFP Doubling across non-phasal islands*

$[_{CP1} \dots th\hat{o}i_{[uQU:EXCL]} \dots [island (non-phasal) \dots [chi/OP_{EXCL[QU:EXCL]} \dots]]]$



5. Concluding remarks

To conclude, empirically, this study has provided novel data to show that AdFoc Doubling (*chỉ...mỗi*) and SFP Doubling (*chỉ...thôi*) in Vietnamese are not uniform and contrast in locality and intervention effects. Analytically, I have argued that different syntactic dependencies are involved in exclusive doubling: (c)overt movement triggered by a focus [FOC] feature for AdFoc Doubling, and an Agree dependency triggered by an exclusive [EXCL] feature for SFP Doubling. Theoretically, I have also proposed that [FOC] and [QU] (quantificational) are different superfeature classes for the evaluation of syntactic minimality.

I have focused primarily on the syntax, but this is only half of the story. Unlike what the operator-particle approach usually claims, *mỗi* and *thôi* are not truly semantically vacuous. While they do not convey exclusivity on the truth-conditional (at-issue) level, they both encode a focus-sensitive, scalar inference on the not-at-issue level, informally as “the focus value is ranked lower than other alternatives on a contextual scale” (similar to the meaning of ‘just’), as argued by Hole (2017) and Yip (2026). How scalar operators combine exclusive operators with the *same* focus without triggering semantic focus intervention is a non-trivial issue (Yip 2024; cf. Erlewine 2025). The current findings on their syntax serve as a useful basis for future semantic work.

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